while the Congress's share here declined to 31 per cent. The BJP also recorded a major gain in Brahmin and Thakur votes which went up to 60 per cent and 58 per cent, respectively, compared to 29 per cent and 32 per cent, respectively, for the Congress. The BJP getting greater support from Brahmins and Thakurs is attributed to its appointing Sharma, a Brahmin, as state chief and Tomar—a CM probable—being the party's Thakur face.

BJP: COLLECTIVE LEADERSHIP WORKS

Aware of the diminishing popularity of Chouhan, party strategists had effectively reduced him to one of the leadership options, instead of the only one. The BJP's carefully crafted campaign strategy involved turning the contest into a Modi vs Nath one, rather than a Chouhan vs Nath one. Once the party moved into campaign mode, all election material prominently displayed Modi's face, with other BJP leaders from the state being placed in much smaller sizes. In contrast, Congress election material had only Nath, with occasional pictures of Priyanka and Rahul Gandhi accompanying his.

The electioneering phase was marked by intensive campaigning by senior BJP leaders—from Modi, Shah, BJP president J.P. Nadda, defence minister Rajnath Singh, women and child development minister Smriti Irani to Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma. At public meetings, the PM spoke of *'Modi ki guarantee'*, highlighting what the Union government had done for the citizens, following it up with a mention of the state government's initiatives. Another slogan that caught on was *'MP ke mann mein Modi aur Modi ke mann mein MP'*. Towards the end of campaigning, Modi held a road show in Indore—the BJP bagged all nine seats in the district; in 2018, it had won six.

The road to political office in MP has always been via winning a majority of Scheduled Caste (SC) and Scheduled Tribe (ST) seats. Hence, a key task for BJP strategists was to get the backing of these communities. In 2023, the BJP won 24 of the 47 seats reserved for STs, against 16 in 2018, and 27 of the 35 seats reserved for SCs, up from 18 in 2018. Exit poll data shows the BJP's share in ST vote went up by 9 percentage points to 44 per cent, even as the Congress's share declined marginally to 45 per cent, from 46 per cent last time. The Gonds—the single largest ST group in the state—continued at a vote share of 49 per cent for the Congress and 42 per cent for the BJP. When it came to the SC vote, the BJP share was at 42 per cent while the Congress's remained constant at 44 per cent. The vote of the Jatavs—the single biggest community among the SCs—remained at 41 per cent for the Congress and 39 per cent for the BJP. In 2018, the state had witnessed major SC-versus-dominant caste riots in Gwalior after a Supreme Court ruling. This had dented the BJP's support among SCs. This time, the party was careful that no such incident was repeated. Also, at the organisational level, the BJP had been holding Samrasta Bhoj or community eating with SC community members to foster greater assimilation.

THE BJP'S CAREFULLY CRAFTED CAMPAIGN STRATEGY INVOLVED TURNING THE CONTEST INTO A MODI VS KAMAL NATH ONE RATHER THAN A CHOUHAN VS NATH ONE

The BJP has also been working on an elaborate pan-India plan to woo tribal voters. Electing a tribal president and notifying the PESA Rules in MP, besides renaming public buildings have been part of the plan. The BJP even won the Sidhi seat, where the incident of urinating on a tribal man had created a furore. Though the tribal vote for the Congress has sloped off a touch, it has not deserted the party. The Congress still holds 22 seats reserved for STs, while one seat went to the Bharat Adivasi Party (BAP) in western MP. A third of all the seats won by the Congress are reserved for STs.

The Congress was hamstrung by multiple issues. While the BJP followed a unitary chain of command, Nath being a senior party leader would brook no interference from the central leadership or elsewhere. A case in point was how key strategist and architect of the Karnataka victory, Sunil Kanugolu, found working in MP extremely difficult. The party just could not execute a smooth campaign like it did in Karnataka. It attempted to raise the corruption issue, much like it did in Karnataka, but it failed to get off the ground.

When results were announced on December 3, there was a general sense of disbelief among Congressmen even as BJP leaders were surprised too. In 2018, the BJP's vote share stood at 41.02 per cent, which has now gone up to 48.55 per cent. The Congress vote share, 40.89 per cent in 2018, has only trimmed a bit to 40.40 per cent in 2023. So, where has the increase in the BJP's vote increase come from? Experts deduce that about 4 per cent of the 7.53 per cent rise has come from women and the rest from the Bahujan Samaj Party, Samajwadi Party, Aam Aadmi Party, NOTA, unrecognised parties and Independents. In 2018, the share of all these put together was 18.09 per cent. Now, it has plummeted to 10.9 per cent in 2023, a reduction of 7.19 percentage points. The Congress, too, lost 0.49 per cent of its vote to the BJP.

The election has felled some BJP biggies too—12 ministers of the 33-member Chouhan cabinet, including the very vocal home minister Narottam Mishra, failed to win their seats. But then the party's resounding victory elsewhere more than made up for these losses. ■